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The trouble with ‘trust’ in news media

Caroline Fisher

News and Media Research Centre, University of Canberra, Australia

ABSTRACT

Questions surrounding trust in news media have preoccupied scholars for almost a century. Based on a review of interdisciplinary literature, this paper provides an overview of the evolution of conceptions of news trust over the past 80 years. In doing so, this paper highlights key problems with the question of trust in this context. First, despite the volume of research on this topic, there is no agreed definition or measure of ‘trust’ in news media. Second, there is a growing disconnect between the normative ideal of an informed citizenry and the complex range of influences on perceptions of news credibility in the digital era. Third, in an age of uncertainty about the veracity of online information, is ‘trust’ in news even desirable? In response to these issues, this paper asks whether research based on undefined general questions about public ‘trust’ in news media continues to be relevant.

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Introduction

The motivation for this paper grew out of a review of interdisciplinary literature on news media trust in response to analysis of data from the Australian edition of the *Reuters Institute Digital News Report* in 2015 and 2016.¹ Both of these surveys show that Australians’ trust in news as being amongst the lowest in World. In the *Reuters Digital News Report 2015 – Australia*, Australia ranked 12th out of the 18 countries surveyed with just under 40% of respondents saying that they generally trusted the news media (Watkins et al., 2015). In the 2016 *DNR* survey, Australians’ trust in news media was again recorded as being lower in comparison to other countries at 43%, placing it just second from the bottom out of the English speaking countries surveyed. Of the 26 countries surveyed in the 2016 *DNR* global study, Finland recorded the highest level of general news trust with 65% and Greece the lowest at 20%. The global *Edelman Trust Barometer* (2016) found similar results, recording 42% trust in media amongst Australians.

Further analysis of the *DNR-Australia* in 2015 and 2016 data found that online news consumers have lower levels of general trust in news media than those who primarily use traditional news media platforms. A correlation between the motivation for news consumption and trust on the 2015 data² further revealed that many news consumers were not motivated to access news media based on the ideal of being an informed

citizen in Democracy. Instead, it found that a desire to be informed was more likely to correlate with trust amongst those who mainly used traditional news media, whereas trust in online news sources by those who used them most was likely to be motivated by daily habitual online activity rather than out of a sense of 'duty as a citizen to stay informed'. This suggested that those who predominantly used online media were not necessarily motivated by a specific intention to become informed via the news media they trusted. Instead, their use of online news media was a consequence or byproduct, rather than a purposeful goal, of their daily online use. Participants also said that they trusted news organisations more than journalists and preferred an algorithm selecting their news for them based on their previous use, rather than an editor deciding what stories they should read (Watkins et al., 2016).

These findings presented a complex picture of 'trust' in relation to different platforms, roles, and motivation for use – a much more complicated picture than the apparently simple conception of 'trust' at the heart of these survey questions. Drawing on these findings and the interdisciplinary literature, this paper charts changing conceptions of 'trust' in news media along with changes in technology. It asks if questions of 'trust' based on normative ideals of the informed citizen need to be augmented to reflect changing conceptions of 'trust' in online and social media.

Framework

To aid discussion of these findings in the data, this paper draws on Uses and Gratifications theory approaches. In basic terms, Uses and Gratifications research has sought to understand 'why' people use media and for what purpose (Huang, 2009, p. 108). It emerged from audience 'media effects' research and seeks to 'interpret people's motives for content choice and the satisfactions looked for and derived from media in terms of everyday social circumstances and needs' (McQuail, 1994, p. 318). A range of typologies have been developed to reflect the diversity of motivations for media use, which show that trust, or the need to access reliable information, is only one driver for people to consume news media (Katz, Blumler, & Gurevitch, 1973; Levy, 1977; Ruggiero, 2000; Wenner, 1985). For instance, Katz et al. (1973) found that media formed a range of psychological functions for people including 'matching their wits against others' and 'providing a framework from one's day' (in Ruggiero, 2000, p. 4). Levy (1977) identified five factors motivating people's television viewing, with 'cognitive orientation' – or staying informed – and 'diversion' – or light relief – emerging as the top two motivators. McQuail, Blumler and Brown (1972) found that people watched television to not only know what was happening but also for personal identification, diversion, and connection with others.

This variation in motivation for media use is explored in the Uses and Gratifications literature. In their exploration of why people use media they do not necessarily trust, Tsfaty and Cappella (2005, p. 253) argued that people use media for a range of reasons other than the desire to be informed: 'It is not just the referential function of news (i.e., the need to learn accurate information about the impersonal world) that drives news consumption'. Instead, Tsfaty and Capella found that people were motivated by a need to understand the world around them, or a 'need for cognition, in consuming media'. Although the Uses and Gratifications approach has been criticised for a lack of

theoretical rigor and conceptual inconsistency, Ruggiero (2000) argued that Uses and Gratification theory is experiencing a revival in the age of hybrid media: 'As new technologies present people with more and more choices, motivation and satisfaction become even more crucial components of audience analysis' (Ruggiero, 2000, p. 14). He explained that it is a useful framework for considering the new range of factors influencing peoples' uses of digital media, such as interactivity, hyper textuality, and interpersonal aspects, and the gratifications they receive from it.

Overview of 'trust' literature

Issues of trust are central to all human social activities. Trust is necessary at both an individual or interpersonal level and at a societal one (Delhey & Newton, 2003). Without trust, a person cannot rely on another for support, nor can he or she be confident that the information they receive from the other is credible. As a result, Coleman (2012, p. 36) explained that trust is 'the foundation of the social relationship that we call citizenship'. For the past 25 years, issues of trust have come to the fore as a result of globalisation, digitisation and a growing focus on the individual over the community in the information age (Putnam, 1995). This era of uncertainty has been variously conceptualised as 'risk society' (Beck, 1992), 'Liquid modernity' (Bauman, 2000), and 'cultural chaos' (McNair, 2006). One of the consequences of this period of instability has been an emerging sense of a 'crisis' of trust in public institutions, politics, and the media (Bogaerts & Carpentier, 2013; Coleman, 2012; O'Neill, 2002). Collapse of the traditional financial model of the news media has led to 'lower returns and resulted in redundancies and restructuring as it stripped wealth from the established enterprises of the news industry' (Picard, 2014, p. 273). In addition to this economic uncertainty, this upheaval has also triggered an 'existential crisis' (McNair, 2013, p. 77) for journalism professionals as they work to define themselves against the blurring boundaries between citizen journalists, blogger, and other communications roles (Carlson & Lewis, 2015; Deuze, 2007; McNair, 2006).

These global trends have also injected a new degree of uncertainty for consumers about the veracity of news media. With the tsunami of information available, it can be difficult 'amid the info-smog' for citizens to find the information they need and trust its authority (Coleman, 2012, p. 36). Poor reporting standards have also contributed to a fall in trust. For instance, the phone hacking scandal in the United Kingdom, which revealed journalists at the now defunct *News of the World* and other Murdoch tabloids had illegally accessed the phone messages of citizens and celebrities in the pursuit of headlines (Davies, 2014). Hoaxes, high-profile cases of plagiarism, and daily inaccuracies and distortion, have all served to undermine the credibility and reliability of journalism in the eyes of the public (Broersma, 2013; Porlezza & Russ-Mohl, 2013; Tsfaty & Cappella, 2003) and led to calls for greater accountability of the media (de Haan & Bardoel, 2011; Finkelstein, 2012; Leveson, 2012). It has also led to a push for greater transparency on the part of journalism practitioners to reveal their editorial decision-making to the public and thereby increase trust (McBride & Rosenstiel, 2014; Weinberger, 2009). Consumers are also being urged to treat online information with greater caution. Rather than blindly trust what they read, they are being encouraged to scrutinise information sources (Gillmor, 2010) and adopt a disposition of 'skeptical

knowing' (Kovach & Rosenstiel, 2010, p. 26). In addition, media literacy is now integrated into school curricula to encourage students to critically analyse the information sources they are exposed to, including the news (Fleming, 2010; Potter, 2013).

At the heart of concern about declining levels of trust in the news media is the normative ideal of the informed democratic citizen and the negative impact an unreliable media and uninformed public can have on democracy (Blumler & Gurevitch, 1995; Coleman, 2012; Dahlgren, 2005; Lewis, Williams, & Franklin, 2008; Lloyd, 2004). As Coleman (2012, p. 36) expressed it:

Because citizenship only works on the basis of common knowledge and shared agreement about ways to live, citizens not only need to become informed themselves, but to trust that others around them are similarly civically informed. Unless we can trust the news media to deliver common knowledge, the idea of the public – a collective entity possessing shared concerns – starts to fall apart.

However, as the literature reveals, user perceptions of trust in news are not necessarily focussed on this normative ideal of the informed citizen.

The scholarship on this topic spans a range of disciplines from media psychology, sociology, communications, journalism, and sociology to advertising, marketing, internet studies, and computing. Given the breadth of material, it is not possible to adequately examine all that has been written. Instead, this article attempts to cut an arc across these diverse fields of scholarship to map the changing conceptions of media trust over more than 80 years. It is a journey from individual assessments of a communicator's credibility based on face-to-face unmediated communication, through to algorithms dictating which news stories will be shared via social media by predicting trust relationships between online users. As technology continues to change and usher in new platforms for media publishing, no doubt further iterations of 'trust' and how to measure it will continue to emerge.

Research into trust in news media belongs to a long history of *credibility* research. As noted by Kiouisis (2001) and Kohring and Matthes (2007) in the literature, the terms trust and credibility are virtually used interchangeably and findings in relation to news media specifically and media generally are also entwined. The literature can be roughly divided into three areas: message credibility – or trust in the information; source credibility – or trust in the provider of the information; and media credibility, which is also called medium or channel credibility – or trust, in the medium through which the news information is relayed. These categories, or similar variations, feature in the scholarship focussing on trust and credibility in the mass media. As Metzger, Flanagin, Eyal, Lemus, and McCann (2003) noted, these categories remain relevant in the digital era; however, each of these categories overlaps particularly in relation to online and social news media. What is clear from the broad body of research is that there is no single definition of trust or credibility in news media and no agreed reliable and valid way to measure it.

Media credibility

Research on media credibility generally refers to conceptions of public trust in a particular news medium, such as newspapers, television, social media, etc. In the

United States, concern with media credibility came to the fore in the 1930s when newspapers feared losing their audience to radio and again in the 1950s to television.

Comparative credibility research began with opinion surveys of audiences by the Roper Organisation (1969, 1975) on behalf of the US Television Information Office. These surveys asked Americans which source of media, newspapers, radio, or television a person was more likely to believe if they contained conflicting reports. The surveys found that there was higher trust in print media than electronic media in the United States until 1960 when the dominance of television began to emerge (Roper, 1969; Roper Organization, 1975). In an attempt to find out why television had overtaken newspapers as the most credible news source in the United States, Westley and Severin (1964) examined the demographic influences on media credibility from a sample of 927 Wisconsin residents. They were asked 'As between television, radio and the newspapers, which one do you feel gives the most accurate and truthful news?' While they were unable to identify a definitive type of person who clearly trusted one medium more than the other, they did find differences between gender, education, urban and rural areas, and partisanship, but not consistently.

The primacy of television as most credible medium was reaffirmed by Abel and Wirth (1977). Using a similar question to the Roper surveys, 681 Detroit adult residents were asked in a cross-sectional telephone survey: 'If you got conflicting reports on a local news story from (their local newspaper) and from Channel (their local TV station), which one would you believe the newspaper story or the television story?' They were also asked to rank the 'truthfulness' and importance of their local news on a scale of 0–100% (Abel & Wirth, 1977, p. 373) and found that television was considered more 'believable' and more 'truthful' than newspapers in the presentation of local news, but as equally important. Gaziano and McGrath (1986) adopted a different measurement of credibility asking participants to rate 16 characteristics in relation to news media from 1 to 5 on a 5-point scale. A factor analysis resulted in 12 characteristics being treated as indicators of news media credibility: whether the story was fair, unbiased, told the whole story, was accurate, respected people's privacy, concerned with people's interests, concerned with community well-being, separated fact from opinion, could be trusted, was concerned with public interest, factual, and the reporters were well trained (Gaziano & McGrath, 1986, p. 454). However, Meyer (1988, p. 570) argued that the index generated by Gaziano and McGrath could have been more discriminating.

In more recent attempts to measure media credibility, Tsfaty and Ariely (2014) conducted a secondary analysis of data collected from 44 countries for the World Values Survey. They found that levels of political interest, interpersonal trust, and exposure to television news and newspapers were positively correlated with trust in media. Education levels and exposure to news on the internet were negatively correlated with trust. However, there are problems with this study. Whilst the paper by Tsfaty and Ariely (2014) is titled 'individual and contextual correlates of trust in Media in 44 countries', the question asked of participants was not about 'trust' but about their level of 'confidence' in a range of civic and commercial organisations including 'the press' and 'television'. It is not clear whether it is confidence in the press and television generally, or in the news provided by those two media.

Similar definitional problems are present in other contemporary surveys of public trust in media. Jones (2004) research into Americans' trust in media did not provide a definition of trust to participants. Surveys such as the regular *Essential Report* in Australia (2015), *Edelman's Global Trust Barometer* (2015), *The Pew Research Centre* survey on the modern news consumer (PEW, 2016), and the *Reuters Digital News Report 2015 – Australia*, all ask participants to rank their trust in news media sources along a multipoint scale. For instance, in the 2015 *Digital News Report* survey, participants were asked 'Thinking about news in general, do you agree or disagree with the following statement?' first, 'I think you can trust most news most of the time'; and, second, 'I think I can trust most of the news that I use most of the time'. All items were answered on a 5-point scale (1 = strongly disagree, 2 = tend to disagree, 3 = neither agree nor disagree, 4 = tend to agree, 5 = strongly agree).³ The *Edelman Global Trust* survey asks

when looking for general news and information, how much would you trust each type of source for general news and information? Please use a nine point scale where one means that "you do not trust it all" and nine means you "trust it a great deal." (Edelman, 2015)

Again, in the *Essential Report* (2015), participants are asked 'How much trust do you have in what you read or hear in the following media?' They then are asked to choose from the options of 'A lot of trust', 'Some trust', 'Not much trust', 'No trust at all', 'Don't know', and 'Don't use'. PEW's survey on the modern news consumer asked respondents: 'How much, if at all, do you trust the information you get from?' (a range of news sources): 'A lot; Some; Not too much; Not at all; No Answer.' (PEW, 2016, p. 36)

None of these surveys provides participants with a definition of trust. Instead, what is relied upon is a common usage or dictionary definition of 'trust', that being a belief in the 'reliability' and 'truth' of someone or something (sourced from Oxford and Cambridge dictionaries, online). In a review of the credibility literature more than a decade ago, Metzger et al. (2003, pp. 308–309) found a range of other adjectives used to describe and measure the credibility of news media. They included believability, accuracy, fairness, bias, trustworthiness, ease of use, completeness, reliability, and attractiveness of the coverage and presenters. In conclusion, they argued that perhaps the 'intense focus on measurement has perhaps come at the cost of developing clear conceptual definitions of media credibility that could be used to form consistent operationalizations of the concept' (Metzger et al., 2003, p. 309).

Source credibility

Generally speaking, the literature on source credibility is concerned with trust in relation to the provider of information. As the review below reveals, in the age of mass media, identification of the source of news was a much easier task than in the digital era. Kioussis (2001) explained that early research into source credibility by the Yale Communication Research Program (Hovland, Janis, & Kelley, 1953; Hovland & Weiss, 1951) centred on perceptions of credibility in relation to individual communicators, such as a public speaker. To find out what qualities would change a participant's attitudes towards a communicator, the researcher first recorded the views of the

participants and then exposed them to ‘manipulated messages’ to see what influence those messages had on the participants’ attitude towards the source. The Yale research revealed the attributes of ‘expertise’ and ‘trustworthiness’ to be key determinants of perceptions of credibility in those who provided information (Kiousis, 2001, p. 383). However, Kohring and Matthes (2007) argued that it was unclear whether ‘expertness’ and ‘trustworthiness’ were dimensions of credibility or predictors of credibility, and while influential, these findings were not validated and lacked a strong theoretical base. In an attempt to address this gap, Kohring and Matthes (2007) published a validated multidimensional scale of trust in news media. In contrast to other models, Kohring and Matthes (2007) brought together journalism theory and trust in news media. Their model was based around the hypotheses that when a person is asked if they trust news media, he or she is really being asked if they trust the selective process of journalism. They described that process as having four dimensions: trust in the selectivity of topics; trust in the selectivity of facts; trust in the accuracy of depictions; and trust in journalistic assessment (analysis), research selectivity, and presentation of relevant information. The theory was tested on two representative samples using confirmatory factor analysis, which confirmed that perceptions of trust in news media were based on perceptions of trust in the journalistic process. This emphasis on trust in the processes of creating journalism was also echoed in the recent work of Blöbaum (2014). In his thorough examination of issues impacting on trust in journalism, he argued that trust is made up of three parts: trust in the journalism system as a whole; trust in journalists as individual actors; and trust in the journalistic method. In a time of economic uncertainty and unlimited competition, Blöbaum (2014, p. 51) argued that it was important to lift public trust in each of these areas, because trust in media organisations is based on the ‘accumulation of journalistic reputation and media credibility. This reputation is anchored in the brand name’. This long established reputation and associated trust is transferred immediately from the offline to the online world. Therefore, improving and maintaining trust in those news brands is central to the financial future of the news media.

Message credibility

In the context of the twenty-first century and digital online media, the literature reveals a shift in conceptions of trust in media with a conflation of the tradition distinctions between source, message, and media (Metzger et al., 2003). Sundar (2015) explained that in the digital environment, these distinct categories are inadequate. The huge number of sources and layers of multimedia information available, combined with the impact that perceptions of technical capabilities can have on credibility perceptions of digital media, means that distinctions between source, medium, and message have become increasingly unclear. Based on a decade’s worth of effects research of digital media, Sundar (2015) developed the M.A.I.N. model to illustrate the way in which technical affordances of digital media can influence credibility assessments of that media, beyond its content. The model is based on four key technical capabilities of digital media – modality, agency, interactivity, navigability. Each of these key affordances is underpinned by web of cues and heuristics that feed into judgements of credibility. Similarly, Metzger et al.

(2003), Flanagin and Metzger (2007), and Dochterman and Stamp (2010) have found that young people in particular will be strongly influenced in their credibility judgments based on surface features such as design appeal, ease of interaction, download speed, and navigability. Flanagin and Metzger (2007) found that the user assessments of credibility were mainly based on design and other website features rather than who the site was sponsored by. Dochterman and Stamp (2010) found twelve factors with varying levels of impact on the credibility judgement of online users. They included authority, page layout, site motive, URL, cross-checkability, user motive, content, date, professionalism, site familiarity, process, and personal beliefs of the user.

What if the story was not written by a human but was written by a robot instead? Recent research by Graefe, Haim, Haarmann, and Brosius (2016) attempted to address this question. In a study involving 986 German participants, they found that 'computer written news tended to be rated higher than human-written news in terms of credibility' (Graefe et al., 2016, p. 10). Stories written by humans, but falsely declared as computer written, 'were perceived as less favorable than the same articles correctly declared as written by a journalist ... although differences in effect sizes were small, the results might tempt publishers to assign human names to computer-written articles' (Graefe et al., 2016, p. 11). With the inevitable increase in computer-generated news, the findings led the authors to call for the development of ethics guidelines in relation to robot or computer-written news.

Beyond technical capabilities influencing perceptions of trust in digital news media, personal relationships with other users play a significant role determining credibility of information shared. For many people accessing news is becoming 'a shared social experience as people swap links in emails, post news stories ... highlight news stories in their Tweets, and haggle over the meaning of events in discussion threads' (Purcell, Rainie, Mitchell, & Olmstead, 2010). This occurs 'as a significant proportion of news consumers turn to family, friends, and acquaintances to alert them to items of interest' (Hermida, Fletcher, Korell, & Logan, 2012, p. 821). Endorsements given by friends have also been found to boost credibility perceptions. Sundar (2015) labelled this the 'bandwagon heuristic', which means that items deemed popular by others increased their status in the eyes of friends: 'If others think it is a good story, then I should think so too' (Sundar, 2015, p. 83). This is supported by a study of millennials and their news habits (MIP, 2015) that found in addition to specifically seeking information; young people have access to a wide range of recommended information from peers in their online network. Choi (2016) has identified four components of news sharing all of which have an impact on credibility perception. The first is 'news browsing' of posts and links received from friends and family; 'news personalizing' which describes receiving news from sources the user subscribes to or from journalists the user follows; the third and fourth are 'news recontextualizing' and 'news endorsing' whereby the users repost items with comments or press the like or favourite icons. A range of motivations have also been identified as having an impact on young peoples' credibility perceptions of media and information. A study of college students by Rieh and Hilligoss (2015) found that the students goal – or need – for the information sought played an important role in determining the credibility of the information they sought. Depending on whether they were seeking information for an essay or for entertainment,

then the need to access credible information was either higher or lower. Depending on the time they had, quick and accessible resources trumped credibility of content.

Instead of friends recommending content, algorithms and recommender systems have emerged as key influences on trust in media (Golbeck & Hendler, 2006). Trust algorithms and reputation systems have been devised to predict and measure trust and distrust in online social networks to identify networks of shared interest and social connection (DuBois, Golbeck, & Srinivasan, 2011; Kim & Ahmad, 2013). In doing so they replace human to human 'word of mouth' spread via genuine relationship connections (Shardanand & Maes, 1995). The results of these equations can then be applied to recommender systems to emulate choices about sharing material that individuals might themselves make. Guy, Zwerdling, Ronen, Carmel, and Uziel (2010) argued that recommender systems based on relationships between people and tags created a more accurate way of identifying user interests, than a system based on relational information alone. However, being able to 'personalise' a user's news feed has raised concerns about limiting an individual's curiosity and exposure to alternative perspectives (Pariser, 2011 in Thurman & Schifferes, 2012, p. 787). This was a concern shared by participants in the DNR-Australia 2016 survey which found that although online news users were concerned about.... Lack of exposure, they did prefer their news to be personalised and tailored to their interests based on their previous consumption. Whether it is preferred or not, Thurman and Schifferes (2012) argue that the ability of online news providers to personalise content to consumer preferences might be part of the solution to stabilising the economic foundations of news journalism.

Discussion

The above brief overview of the interdisciplinary literature, though not exhaustive, highlights a range of problems with the conception of 'trust' in news media. First, it is clear that there is no agreed definition or measure of trust. Despite ongoing attempts to develop reliable measures, no single model that spans all news media – traditional and online – has been adopted. Instead, what is found is a diversity of conceptions of trust that have evolved alongside changes in media technology and will yield different responses depending on which aspect of trust is being measured: the message, the medium, or the source or all three at once. The problem is exacerbated by the fluidity of definitions around terms such as 'source'. As the above literature shows, this can refer to an individual reporter; a robot; media organisation; a particular newspaper, website, App, or TV programme; a friend who shared it, or algorithm that selected it.

As a result, simple questions about whether consumers 'trust' the news media they consume belie the complexity of the issue. Is the news consumer being asked if they trust the processes of journalism to produce reliable, accurate interpretation of events as suggested by Blöbaum (2014)? Or are they being asked if they trust an online news website based on its technical features, interactivity, navigability, and aesthetic appeal (Dochterman & Stamp, 2010; Flanagin & Metzger, 2007)? Or are they being asked if they trust the friend or family member who sent it to them (Choi, 2016; Hermida et al., 2012)? Or indeed if they trust the algorithm that determined what they should read based on previous preferences and online connections (Shardanand & Maes, 1995;

Thurman & Schifferes, 2012)? Or are they being asked if they trust the robot that produced it, or the human reporter who wrote it?

The second problem stems from the traditional normative concerns about the importance of a reliable-free press and informed citizenry in order to democracy to function effectively. Uses and Gratifications research shows that consumers of news media are not necessarily motivated by a sense of civic duty to be informed when they consume media. In fact, people often consume media they do not trust. While that might not seem ‘rational’, as Tsftati and Capella (2005, p. 254) put it, studies reveal that ‘obtaining accurate and objective information about the world is just one motivation for watching the news’. Given the large number of emerging factors identified in the literature that can impact on user perceptions of trust in online and social media, it cannot be assumed that media users will be motivated by the normative ideal of being a well-informed citizen in their consumption of news media: ‘When other motivations are present, trust in the media becomes less relevant’ (Capella & Tsftati, 2015, p. 254).

Research shows that the line between news media and other forms of information via social media and online platforms is blurring with traditionally separate areas of credibility research – source, media, and message – being conflated (Metzger et al., 2003). Online and mobile users don’t necessarily seek news, they simply bump into it or encounter and interact with news as they wander through their media-saturated lives (Deuze, 2012; Hermida et al., 2012). Relying on the assumption that the news consumer will interpret trust based on traditional conceptions of reliability and accuracy bound up in the ideal of the informed citizen, does not adequately accommodate how and why people are accessing news media. This is supported by the *DNR 2015* data which showed that people predominantly using online media were not necessarily motivated by a specific intention to become informed via the news media they trusted, instead their use of online news media was a consequence or byproduct, rather than a purposeful goal, of their daily online use.

A third problem is a disconnection between the ideal of being able to ‘trust’ the news media, and the growing need for journalists and consumers to verify online information (Brandtzaeg, Lüders, Spangenberg, Rath-Wiggins, & Følstad, 2015; Silverman, 2013). In response to the tsunami of online information, consumers are being encouraged to be more media literate, sceptical, and not blindly trust what they read. In their book *Blur*, Kovach and Rosenstiel (2010) describe the desired disposition of the contemporary news consumer as the ‘way of sceptical knowing’. The authors encourage the public to ask a range of questions to test the quality of a source and its information, such as What kind of content am I encountering?; Is the information complete? What is missing?; What evidence is presented and how was it tested or vetted?; and What might be an alternative understanding or explanation? Similarly, Gillmor (2010) urges consumers to be sceptical, exercise their judgement, open his or her mind, and to keep asking questions.

In journalism education, students are being taught the importance of verification, especially in relation to online and social media (Silverman, 2013). The distinction between verified pieces of journalism and information that has not been through journalistic process of fact and source checking is seen as central to defining the boundaries of a profession that is under threat from other communications roles. In response, there is increasing emphasis on media literacy in journalism schools. Students

are being encouraged to engage critically with the media and information they are consuming and not to simply 'blindly accept the curriculum that media are already teaching students outside of classrooms' (Fleming, 2014, p. 3). In the wider education system, students are being taught to understand the difference between their 'real world and the world manufactured by the media', to be discriminating about what they consume and avoid media exposures that are harmful to them (Potter, 2013, p. 10). In other words, consumers of online and social media are being discouraged from accepting what they read, watch, and hear at face value. They are being encouraged to be more media literate, to be sceptical, and not blindly trust what they find online. As a result, asking younger online users whether they 'trust' the news media might seem counter-intuitive. Having been taught to critically evaluate the news media is it surprising if they answer 'no' or 'undecided' in response to a simple question about whether they 'trust' it? Answering in the negative would be a literate response for those who have undergone some form of media literacy training. This would appear to be supported by the *DNR 2016 – Australia* survey which found that 'those with some university education and postgraduate education are less likely to trust news most of the time than those with a high-school education or less' (p. 61); however, further research needs to be done to establish this link. Given the emphasis on critical analysis of information in a 'post-fact' society when 'facts no longer matter' (Manjoo, 2011), is 'trust' in news media even desirable?

Conclusion

This paper has identified three problems (there will be others) with the conception of 'trust' in relation to news media: The lack of definition and measurement of 'trust'; the disconnection between the normative ideal of an informed citizenry and the realities of news consumption in the digital era; and questions about the desirability of 'trusting' news media in a 'post-fact' society. Each of these points to a need for a deeper and more nuanced approach to assessing consumer perceptions of news information rather than simply asking someone to rate their level of 'trust' in the news on a scale of 1–5. Surveys of news consumers need to accommodate the range of influences, motivations, and technological characteristics that might impact on their judgement. In an online environment where hard news and selfies all blend on the one feed, it is becoming increasingly difficult to discern what is 'news' and who or what is the source of that information. Accordingly, researchers need to be clear about what element of news media is being asked about, whether it is the content, the brand, an individual reporter, a friend who shared it, or an algorithm that sent it. In light of concerns about the unreliability of online information and the push for consumers to develop a 'way of sceptical knowing', perhaps simple questions of 'trust' in news media need to be reconsidered in order to embrace the complexity of changing conceptions of 'trust' in the digital era and thereby remain relevant.

Notes

1. The author is a member of the News & Media Research Centre at the University of Canberra which produced the Australian edition of the Digital News Report in 2015 and 2016.

2. The 2016 *Reuters Institute Digital News Report* survey did not ask questions about motivation for news consumption.
3. The UK edition of the 2016 *Reuters Institute Digital News Report* did also include additional qualitative questions about news trust. This was not done in Australia.

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